

| CDN Incident Alert: 0083. TLP: CLEAR |                                                                                       | Date       |
|--------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------|
| Title                                | MD Claim about Moldovan soldiers dying in Ukraine amplified across multiple platforms | 29/08/2025 |

### Summary

- Between July 13-pro-Russian and Russian state-affiliated media amplified an unfounded claim that Moldovan soldiers died in Ukraine.
- It conveyed the narrative that Moldovan President Maia Sandu and NATO are dragging Moldova into war.
- The narrative was amplified on multiple platforms and was reported on by Russian state-run and pro-Kremlin media, including sanctioned entities.
- The operation is targeting Moldovan citizens by exploiting existing narratives aimed at undermining trust towards state institutions and the country's foreign policy course.
- Government, media, and local counter-disinformation organizations should raise awareness on how the narrative is being exploited and manipulated ahead of elections.

### Incident

Russian state-controlled and affiliated media outlets [Vzglyad](#), [RT](#), [RIA Novosti](#), [Sputnik](#), [Tsargrad](#), [Vedomosti](#), [TASS](#), and others, amplified claims from the Telegram channel [@real\\_moldavsky](#), which on July 13 [alleged](#), citing an unnamed source, that four of 10 Moldovan soldiers deployed to Ukraine were killed and two wounded “for Sandu’s political ambitions.” The post accused Sandu of secretly sending troops under a personal deal with the President of Ukraine, Volodymyr Zelenskyy, and paying families to stay silent under threat. Following the official rebuttal of the claim by the Ministry of Defense of Moldova, the channel [@real\\_moldavsky](#) [posted](#) a new iteration of the claim on July 29, alleging that Sandu needed to mobilize 70,000 Moldovan “mercenaries” to fight in Ukraine by October 1 to receive €1 billion in “investments,” or else Moldova will face default.

Vasile Tarlev, former Prime Minister and leader of the “Future of Moldova” party, [accused](#) PAS of eroding Moldova’s neutrality and dragging the country into war, calling for an independent investigation into the alleged soldier deaths. The narrative appeared at least 82 times on X, with 48 posts citing or retweeting [@otdelenie](#). On Telegram, it was shared at least 183 times, including in channels linked to Evrazia. Russian Duma member and Evrazia Council Chair Alyona Arshinova [claimed](#) the deaths signaled Moldova’s full integration into NATO and preparations for a joint action in Transnistria. On TikTok, suspicious accounts ([one](#), [two](#), and [three](#)) spread the narrative using emotionally charged hashtags in Russian and Romanian, such as [#МыНеХотимУмирать](#) (We don’t want to die), [#ЧужаяВойна](#) (Not our war), and [#МыХотимЖить](#) (We want to live). The videos featured manipulative messaging, often accompanied by background music and AI-generated voiceovers repeating the initial disinformation claim.

### Systemic Violation Assessment:

- I. The incident threatens Moldova’s electoral process by exploiting fear and warmongering narratives. Its goal is to discredit the Sandu government, portraying it as disastrous and dangerous for the country’s future.
- II. The Moldovan Ministry of Defense refuted the claim that Moldovan soldiers died in Ukraine. The narrative was amplified through TikTok using AI-generated voiceovers to heighten emotional appeal and attract local audiences. Suspicious X and TikTok accounts further spread the claim, with some X accounts having verified blue badges.
- III. The incident was not illegal.

### Narrative:

**Meta narrative:** NATO seeks to drag Moldova into war.

**Sub-narratives:** Maia Sandu is sacrificing Moldovan lives for Western interests; Moldova is secretly involved in the war despite constitutional neutrality; Moldova is preparing military action in Transnistria with NATO/Ukraine support.

## Impact

**Reach:** According to Osavul data, the total number of views across all messages in the dataset was 2,259,224. The original post by @real\_moldovsky was reposted 120 times and received 62,700 views.

**Outcome:** N/A

## Key Objectives and Behaviors (DISARM Red Framework)

**Objective:** [T0135.003: Subvert](#)– Narrative aims to sabotage and undermine Moldova’s foreign policy course.

**Objective:** [T0135.001: Smear](#)– Narrative aims to discredit NATO and Ukraine.

[T0003: Leverage Existing Narratives](#) – A well-circulated narrative about the West attempting to drag countries into war, with Ukraine cited as a case study, was adapted to the Moldovan context.

[T0015.001: Use Existing Hashtag](#) – Hashtags on TikTok were used before this specific claim emerged.

[T0097.202: News Outlet Persona](#) – Multiple Russian state-affiliated media disseminated the narrative.

[T0119.002: Post Across Platform](#) – The narrative was amplified on multiple platforms, including news websites, Telegram, TikTok, VK, and Facebook.

## Recommendations and Actions Taken

**Action taken:** The Ministry of Defense of Moldova refuted the claim.

**Recommendations:** Raise further awareness of how the narrative is manipulated to evoke emotional reactions and influence voters ahead of the elections.

| Report | Threat Actor | Evidence     | Authors             | Platforms                        | <a href="#">FIMI Assessment</a> |
|--------|--------------|--------------|---------------------|----------------------------------|---------------------------------|
| NA     | Russia       | Upon request | Sopo Gelava, DFRLab | Telegram,<br>Facebook,<br>TikTok | High certainty                  |